

Carcharodon carcharias

White shark



Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide; occasionally in cold waters

Length 20 ft (6 m), max 26 ft (8 m)

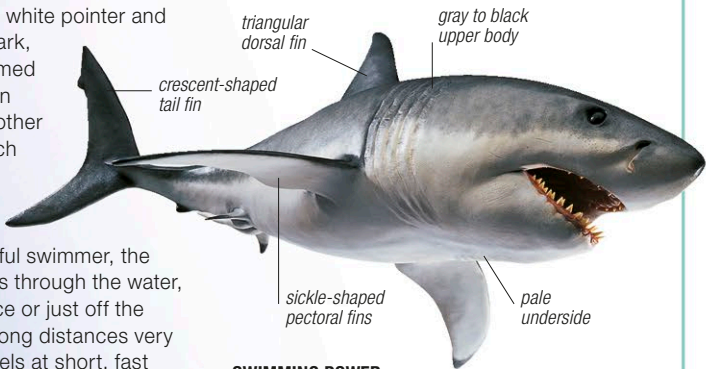
Weight 2³/₄ tons (2 tonnes) or more

Breeding Viviparous

Status Vulnerable



Also known as the white pointer and the great white shark, this species is blamed for more attacks on humans than any other shark—but research shows that most human victims are quickly released. A powerful swimmer, the white shark cruises through the water, either at the surface or just off the bottom, covering long distances very quickly. It also excels at short, fast chases, and may leap spectacularly out of the water. Like other members of its family, it can maintain its muscles at an unusually high temperature, helping it to swim and hunt more efficiently, especially in cold water. Although usually solitary, it may sometimes be seen in pairs or small groups feeding at a carcass, with larger individuals eating first. The sharks may also swim in a variety of patterns in order to establish their dominance hierarchy. The primary prey of adults is seals, sea lions, dolphins, and large fishes, including other sharks—but this species



SWIMMING POWER

The white shark powers through the water with sideways beats of its tail. Its fixed pectoral fins prevent it from nose-diving, and its large dorsal fin aids stability.

AWESOME WEAPONS



Armed with its large, triangular, coarsely serrated teeth, the white shark is superbly equipped for ripping into the flesh of its unfortunate prey. In some situations, this shark has been known to swim along with its teeth bared, which may serve to warn off competitors for food, or rival sharks intruding on its personal space.

THE GREAT “MAN-EATER”

This very large, formidable-looking shark is greatly feared as a man-eater, partly due to the media fascination that followed the release of the film *Jaws*. However, according to the International Shark Attack File, there have been fewer than 100 confirmed human deaths due to unprovoked white shark attacks since records began.